Indigo

Intuition · insight · depth

Indigo may recall an evening sky, ink or the deep blue of fabric. Sometimes you can make out a violet tint in it, other times you would simply call it dark blue. In spiritual texts it seems mysterious, but in your wardrobe you probably know it quite intimately. A colour linked with the third eye you can, after all, wear when popping out for bread rolls. In the form of favourite jeans.

This page does not tell you what indigo means. **It shows it to you from several sides**. How it is mixed, how you paint with it, where its strength comes from, how it is read in different cultures and **what it can awaken in us**. Read only what speaks to you and stop at the questions. The answers are neither right nor wrong, they are just yours.

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How to mix the colour and its shades

One name, several forms. Indigo is the name of a dye and also of a colour shade. The traditional indigo dye gives fabrics a blue colour. In today's colour charts “indigo” may denote a deep blue and also a more striking blue-violet, and individual painting brands offer different mixes under this name. That is why there is no single tube that is the one correct indigo. For our card imagine **a deep blue with a slight violet tint**. Blue still predominates in it.

Real dyeing with indigo has its own little show. In traditional dyeing the dye is first chemically treated so that it can pass into the dye bath. The fabric may look yellow-green when pulled out and only **turn blue in the air**. The change is caused by contact with oxygen. When painting with ordinary paints do not expect such a change. The deep shade here is made by mixing ready-made colours.

What to prepare



Blue
The base of the mix. Ultramarine is a striking blue with a slightly violet tint.



White
For lighter and denim variants.



Black
Or for darkening. Use it sparingly so that the mix does not lose its colour.



Magenta
A pinkish red that carefully pushes blue towards violet.



Brown
In a tiny amount for more muted ink tones.

How can you recognise it without technical names?

Indigo side by side quickly shows whether it is **bluer** or **more violet**. A bluer one recalls denim and ink, a more violet one the evening sky just before dark. The names on tubes differ between makers, so put small samples side by side and **add white** to part of them. You will then see the hidden tint better.

On the tube look for the marking **PB** (Pigment Blue) and **PV** (Pigment Violet) and a number. It tells you which pigments the mix is made of, even when the names differ.

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What the additions do



Magenta

Pushes towards violet, plum. Add by the tip, it easily takes over.





White

Lightens and leads to denim and dusk. Add little by little.





Brown

Mutes towards ink. Too much brown quickly makes it a dirty grey.





Black

Darkens, but flattens. Add only on the tip of the brush.





Orange

The opposite of blue. In a tiny amount it calms and softens indigo.





Blue

Returns it to bluer, denim and ink.



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Ten indigos to try

A part can be a drop, or a pile of paint of the same size. **Take the proportions as a starting point for trying things out**, not as a recipe for a cake. The strength of pigments differs and dark colours can take command surprisingly fast. Start with blue. Magenta is meant to turn the mix slightly, it does not have to take the lead in it.

Classic indigo



3 + 1

6 parts blue + 1 part red or magenta. Deep, calm, a little mysterious.

Bluer indigo



2 + 1

4 parts darker blue + a tiny addition of magenta. The proportion is approximate, add the magenta really by the tip.

Blue-violet indigo



3 + 1

3 parts blue + about 1 part magenta, fine-tune according to the result. Closer to violet, but still with a blue base.

Midnight



3 + 1 + 1

6 parts ultramarine + 1 part brown + a trace of magenta, possibly a tiny bit of black. A deep night in which stars can be found.

Denim



4 + 1 + 1

4 parts blue + 1 part white + a drop of brown. Comfortable, everyday, washed.

Dusk



1 + 3

1 part indigo + 3 parts white. Soft, dreamy, gently sad.

Smoky blue-violet



1 + 3 + 1

1 part indigo + 3 parts white + a tiny trace of brown. Like mist over water.

Plum



3 + 1

3 parts indigo + 1 part red or magenta. Richer, warmer, closer to violet.

Grey indigo



3 + 2 + 1

3 parts indigo + 2 parts white + a trace of orange. Calm, elegant. Orange is the opposite of blue and mutes it.

Slate



3 + 1 + 1

3 parts indigo + 1 part grey + a pinch of green. Cool, sober, grounded.

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Rainbow – the chakra system

In the usual order of seven colours indigo stands between blue and violet. In the contemporary rainbow map of the chakras it is linked with the **sixth chakra** and the themes of **intuition**, **imagination** and discernment. Blue may ask “what do I need to say?”, indigo “what is beginning to dawn on me?” and violet “what sense does this make for me?”

The whole rainbow as a map of questions



Red · root
Safety, support, presence. Ask yourself. What can I lean on?



Orange · sacral
Experiencing, pleasure, sensuality. Ask yourself. What does me good?



Yellow · solar plexus
Self-worth, will, decision-making. Ask yourself. What do I want to choose for myself?



Green · heart
Closeness, kindness, relationships. Ask yourself. Where can I be open and still stay with myself?



Blue · throat
Voice, expression, communication. Ask yourself. What do I need to say?



Indigo · third eye
Inner vision, intuition, discernment. Ask yourself. What is beginning to dawn on me?



Violet · crown
Transcendence, meaning, connection. Ask yourself. What gives me a wider sense of meaning?

The rainbow in reality passes smoothly between shades. Seven names help describe its form, the individual bands are not separated by a line. This chakra map too is **a certain way of arranging things**. Older yogic descriptions use other colour associations.

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Ajna, the third eye

The chakras come from the Indian yogic and tantric tradition. The sixth chakra is called Ajna (Sanskrit for “command”, “authority” or “to perceive”). It sits in the middle of the forehead, between the eyebrows. The lotus has two petals with the syllables “ham” and “ksham” and the syllable **Om** belongs to it. It is linked with intuition, reason and the unconscious. Indigo is tied to it only in today's popular version. In classical descriptions rather white elements are given (petals, moon, lingam).

Its theme is **insight**, clarity and trust in your own perception. For women this often turns into questions. Do I trust my hunch? Do I see things as they are, even when they are unpleasant? Do I hear myself?

When the chakra is open. You hear your inner voice and can be guided by it. You do not need to keep reassuring yourself with others. You can see connections and do not have to watch yourself while doing it.

When the chakra is closed. The tradition describes uncertainty about what to trust, excessive thinking, or, on the contrary, ignoring your own hunch. Closed does not mean bad. It is only a signal that you perhaps do not yet allow yourself **your own insight**.

Modern readings place here, for example, mistrust of your own judgement, a need for constant confirmation from outside or a feeling that your own imagination has no place. These are themes for self-reflection. From no single manifestation can the state of a chakra be determined.

How to add indigo when insight is missing

- **Wear it**
  An indigo scarf, jumper or jeans. Something that calms you and holds you.
- **Put it in your home**
  An indigo cushion or blanket, a deep blue lamp. In the evening, when things slow down.
- **Eat it**
  Blueberries, blackberries or red cabbage. Slowly and perhaps in the evening by a window.
- **Take it with you**
  An indigo pebble, hair tie or small piece of jewellery. Something for your pocket that you reach for when you want to slow down for a moment.
- **Paint it**
  Large dark areas and in the middle a small light spot, with no goal and no judging.
- **Give yourself a small thing**
  An indigo pencil, notebook or mug just for pleasure.

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How to supplement indigo when you bury yourself in yourself

When you have looked inward a lot and miss people in the world, you do not need more indigo, but **light and warmth**.

- **Add yellow or orange**
  Light in the dark. A lamp, a candle, an orange scarf.
- **Add white**
  Clarity and purity. White bed linen, white walls.
- **Add brown**
  Support and stability. Wood, natural materials, the ground under your feet.
- **Invite someone over**
  The warmth of others brings a person back from the head into the world.

This is inspiration from tradition, not treatment. Try gently and notice how you actually feel afterwards.

Picture it with an example

You are deciding. You listened to a friend, read several articles and someone else is just sending you their guaranteed opinion. There is more information. But you are no clearer. This is exactly where indigo can get a personal meaning. **Give yourself a moment in which you stop collecting further answers** and notice your own too.

Next to indigo other colours can stand out more. Yellow appears as light in the night, white as a star and green as the shadow of leaves. **These are possibilities of a personal reading**, not effects prescribed by a combination of colours.

How to use this map

It is a way of sorting out the themes you are living through. Do you add indigo because you miss depth and a quiet space for your own opinion? Or do you take it away because it is already dim enough in your head? **You choose the meaning.** An added colour does not diagnose your state.

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Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort at a pretty picture, **indigo** often appears at a moment when we need **quiet**, or when we want to look **inward**. We do not always know why, though. Sometimes we know exactly why, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind an indigo stroke

The same indigo line on paper can mean **something completely different every time**, depending on what is happening in us just then. Sometimes it is **quiet**, sometimes **fear of the unknown**, sometimes simply the taste of the colour. That is why there is no point in reading a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Depth and quiet.

Large dark areas, circles heading towards the centre. The colour is calm and in no hurry.

Intuition and a hunch.

Oval shapes, an eye or a vertical axis in the middle of the paper. Something in you is opening and you do not yet know what.

Sadness and loneliness.

Dark, cold areas low on the paper, often without another colour. A colour that closes in on itself.

Fear of the unknown.

Dark, dense areas in which nothing can be made out. Like standing before a door you will not yet open.

Dreams and night.

Tiny light dots on a dark background, stars, a moon. Something that appears in the dark.

A need for distance.

An indigo wall or curtain across part of the paper. A colour that says “leave me alone for a while”.

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A dark colour does not have to mean a dark period

Perhaps you are drawn to its **fullness**. Perhaps you have finally found a colour that can carry a large area. Or you enjoy how a single light stroke stands out beside it. **From an indigo picture it cannot be determined** that you are sad, withdrawn or exceptionally intuitive. In work inspired by art therapy we are interested in your own experience. What happened while painting and what you recognise in the picture later.

A predominance of indigo alone is not enough for a verdict on whether it is calm or tiredness. **Maybe you wanted to rest**. Maybe the darkest tube simply fell into your hand.

I want it on canvas, I do not dare to put it on myself

An indigo picture and an indigo coat may ask two completely different things of you. On canvas you give space to an experience. In clothing you may feel that the colour connects you with a uniform or a role that you do not want. **The canvas can carry everything** you need to say in it, and you do not have to **buy anything new** for that.

On canvas you can give it enormous space and you do not have to accept at the same time the idea of how you yourself will look in it. **Canvas can be a safe place** where you allow expression in your own way.

Sometimes you want to wear it, sometimes just paint it. Sometimes you enjoy the night sky on paper and would not take a dark blue coat even for free. The two do not exclude each other.

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When indigo takes over the space

First let it come. Maybe you reach for indigo and have no idea why. Let it appear on the canvas **without any duty to explain** whether it is quiet, sadness, a hunch or a memory of the night sky above a country cottage. You can paint standing, on the floor, with your hand, a brush or a piece of cloth. What matters is what happens to you as you spread the colour, layer it or let it take up more room.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

Enveloped, or room?

A large indigo area can recall a pleasant sense of being enveloped. At other times it starts to feel heavy. A small trace can be precious and striking. It does not have to be large to carry an important feeling for you. Do I feel like extending the indigo, leaving it, or stepping back from it?

- **SATURATION**

Light, or rich?

By adding white you lighten the colour. By adding a suitable earthier tone you can mute it without it lightening markedly. These bring different experiences. Perhaps you do not need a lighter picture, just a less sharp colour expression. Try the change first in a small place.

- **THICKNESS**

What does it feel like under your hands?

Thick paint you can push, spread and layer. Thin paint creates transparency, running and unexpected paths. Sometimes you enjoy the resistance of the material. At other times the chance to let go of exact guidance. Neither alone reveals your character.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the indigo stroke looks. What matters is what you feel while making it, what situation you are in and what is happening in your life. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One was made on a calm evening, the other after a day when you did not want to talk to anyone. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year it may suddenly dawn on you: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in myself then.” That is fine. **The picture will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

Neither is wrong and neither is right. Quiet, longing, a hunch and fear of the dark all belong to you and indigo can **carry everything**.

If very strong or painful feelings appear while you paint, **do not stay with them alone**. Talk about them with someone close or with an art therapist or therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “indigo = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly often. They are usually made up of three layers, **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Indigo is the colour of **dusk** and **deep night**. When it gets dark, light fades and the eyes adjust. The world calms and loses detail. Indigo says. **Now is the time to be still and look inward.** At the same time, though, the body naturally links dark colours with uncertainty, and so it can sometimes be oppressive too.

From culture

Indigo is worn in jeans, uniforms and evening dresses. It is the colour of depth, expertise and mystery, but also the colour of work. The same colour that a labourer wears in overalls decorates the packaging of luxury goods. **It depends on where we grew up.** In the section on cultures we will look at this in more detail, because indigo also carries heavy stories.

From what you have lived

Favourite jeans, the night sky above a country cottage, a school uniform, a dark blue coat from mum, an evening bus. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same indigo** and one feels calm, the other uncertainty. The colour is the same. The story is not.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is “indigo” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What comes to mind first when I see a woman in an indigo coat or a man in a dark blue shirt?**

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Stories

A colour that is from India

The word indigo comes from the Latin **indicum** and the Greek indikon, that is “Indian”. The dye was imported to Europe from India and as the name of a colour it is first attested in English in **1289**. The name of the colour is the name of the country it came from. The dye is obtained mainly from the plant **Indigofera tinctoria**, in Europe a similar blue was obtained from woad (Isatis tinctoria).

Newton and the seven colours

Isaac Newton distinguished seven colours in the rainbow and linked them with the seven tones of the musical scale. He himself, though, wrote that colours pass smoothly one into another, so the number seven was **his choice**, not a physical fact. Some researchers think that Newton's “indigo” is what we now call blue, others reject this. Indigo is thus partly **a musical decision**.

Blue gold and its price

Indigo was for a long time rare and expensive. Behind its beauty, though, were heavy stories. On plantations in America, for example in South Carolina, in Haiti and in Jamaica, it was grown using **the labour of enslaved people**. In India the Bengal uprising against the exploitation by European planters arose in 1859 and the play Nil Darpan tells of it. In 1917 a wave of resistance rose in the Champaran region of Bihar. Peasants were obliged to sow part of their land with indigo. **Gandhi** went there to investigate their complaints and when the authorities ordered him to leave, he refused. It was his first act of civil disobedience in India. A colour of beauty often stood on work that was not beautiful.

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Emotions and feelings

The same indigo can awaken **calm** in one of us and **uncertainty** in another, sometimes even both in one day.

Indigo can awaken in us **quiet**, **a hunch** and **fear of the unknown**. There is no single fixed effect. It depends on our body, experience, culture and situation.

Emotions

Quick and strong reactions that may appear before you are even aware of them.

Depth and quiet

A feeling that the world has **calmed down** and **wants nothing from me**. The head slows.

And why?

Dusk and night. Indigo is a colour that **switches off needless noise**.

Ask yourself

"When did I last find myself in real quiet?"

Intuition and a hunch

A feeling that I know something even though I cannot explain it. **A quiet inner voice** that speaks up when I am not drowning it out.

And why?

Indigo is linked with the "third eye" and insight. At the same time **intuition is not magic, but experience** that we have not gone through in words. **You can take a feeling seriously** without immediately declaring it true.

A question for you

"What do I know, although I cannot prove it?"

Solitude and longing

A feeling that I am alone even when there are people around. Sometimes chosen solitude, sometimes unplanned.

And why?

Dark cold colours increase distance. Indigo can **both protect and separate**.

If I asked you now

"Is my solitude chosen, or did it happen to me?"

Fear of the unknown

Fear of what hides **beneath the surface**. Uncertainty about what I will find when I look inward.

And why?

The body reads dark colours as uncertainty. I do not see everything. **Fear of the unknown is human** and **does not have to be weakness**.

Try asking yourself

"What am I afraid I will find inside?"

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Focus and insight

A clear, calm head. A feeling that I see things **in context**.

And why?

A deep blue is, according to experience and traditions, the colour of focus and insight. **The colour will not give it to you**, it can only help create a calm environment.

Ask yourself

"When do I think best?"

Aloofness and coldness

A feeling of distance, of lack of interest. Sometimes protection, sometimes freezing.

And why?

Indigo is a cold colour and cold colours increase distance. **For one person it is calm, for another distance**.

A question for you

"Is the distance I keep a choice, or a defence?"

Why do I want it right now?

Perhaps you want **privacy**. Perhaps you are drawn to the firmness of a deep shade. Perhaps you have had enough bright stimuli and appreciate a colour that does not press on you so urgently.

And why?

It can also relate to a memory. A favourite dress, an evening by the water, an old fabric. The colour itself will not say which of the paths belongs to you. **Try keeping it near you for a while** and then putting it away. Is something more pleasant? Do you notice the difference only in the evening? Or do you enjoy it when painting but do not want it in the room? **Research, moreover, does not see** indigo as a clear "colour of sadness". In one study some participants linked it with sadness, but the agreement was not so strong.

If I asked you now

"When does indigo do me good and when do I not want to see it?"

When you get lost in the depth

You keep replaying the same conversation and no further information is added. **This is a moment for a break from analysis.**

And why?

Put the notebook aside, draw the curtains, go outside or do something with your hands. You can also step away from your own head for a while. You are not giving up insight by doing so. **You are giving it room** to appear by itself.

Try asking yourself

"What would help me return to the body?"

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My indigo is not the same as your indigo

A colour itself **does not experience anything**. We experience it. When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), the experience sticks to it. **The colour then becomes a shortcut**. It is enough to catch sight of it and the body knows whether it can relax or should withdraw. That is why **your own reaction** matters most.

- **Jeans**
  For one comfort and freedom, for another a compulsory uniform in which she never felt like herself.
- **The night sky**
  For one calm and stars, for another fear of the dark and of loneliness.
- **A dark blue uniform**
  For one a feeling of order and togetherness, for another school or a job she wants to escape from.
- **An indigo room**
  For one cosiness, for another tightness and distress.
- **The evening bus**
  For one a safe return home, for another a journey on which she was afraid.

Why does it attract me when I am not actually calm?

Perhaps it does not express how you feel. **Perhaps you are drawn to what you are missing**. After a long noise and rush indigo can recall **a dusk that finally switches off an excess of stimuli**. Sometimes you are tired precisely because everything around you keeps shining and shouting. And suddenly the sight of a dark fabric calms you simply because it is soft, quiet and wants nothing from you.

Why does it seem unpleasant to me, on the contrary?

Indigo is too dark for you. It reminds you of a uniform, a dark room or an environment where you did not feel well. **A dislike of indigo does not have to mean** that you reject calm or night. Perhaps you are only rejecting a particular memory. Try to tell whether all dark blues bother you or only a certain kind. Faded jeans can be pleasant even if you would not want a dark blue wall even in a photograph.

Some colours we put aside. After a hard period we get rid of a dress or avoid a place. **It is a way of protecting ourselves**. And when we are ready, **indigo often comes back by itself**, first as jeans, then as an evening on the balcony.

When to add it and when to take it away

Add it where it calms you and opens something pleasant. **Take it away when you catch yourself** hiding in it, everything feels too heavy or you finally want more light and people. Notice the changes. Denim does me good, midnight oppresses me. In winter it attracts me more than in hot summer. These are your concrete experiences. They do not have to fit into one answer “I like indigo”.

If I asked you now

“Which sentence about indigo is loudest in me and whose is it actually?”

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Indigo in cultures and traditions

Indigo is a colour that people grew, traded, wore and also fought battles over. Behind the beauty of its shade stand **both work and pain**. Let us look attentively and gently at a few places, because some of these stories are heavy.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how indigo is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image. For each tradition I say what really stands in it and what is a later interpretation.

Indigo in different cultures

Japan

Indigo is a traditional colour in Japan and to this day it is called “Japanese blue”. In the Edo period (1603 to 1867) common people were forbidden to wear silk, and so cotton and indigo were used more. Dyeing was done in fermentation vats and fabrics were decorated with the techniques shibori, kasuri, katazome and tsutsugaki.

From a practical and later also aesthetic tradition. Indigo was available and durable. The emblem of the Tokyo Olympic Games was a chequerboard in indigo blue (the ichimatsu moyo pattern from the Edo period), which was meant to express elegance and “unity in diversity”.

A colour born of necessity can become **national elegance**. **Restriction often gives birth to beauty**.

India

In India indigo has been grown since antiquity and from there the dye reached Europe. In colonial times it became a crop that some peasants were forced to grow. In 1859 the Bengal uprising against exploitation arose and the play Nil Darpan tells of it. In 1917 in Champaran peasants were obliged to sow part of their land with indigo and Gandhi undertook his first act of civil disobedience in India there.

From the colonial exploitation of agricultural labour. **The action led to a settlement** and the end of this system.

A colour that we wear quite naturally may have behind it **a story that is good not to forget**.

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West Africa

The dyers of the Yoruba (Nigeria) and the Mandinka (Mali) were known for their skill. In Kano in Nigeria the Kofar Mata dye pits still stand, said to be hundreds of years old. The Tuareg are called “the blue people” because indigo from their robes coloured their skin.

From the trans-Saharan trade and from a craft passed down in families. Today it faces pressure from the city, the environment and the declining interest of young people.

A colour can be **craft, family and memory**. When you wear it, you also wear the work that stands behind it.

The Americas

In the American colonies, for example in South Carolina, in Haiti and in Jamaica, indigo was grown with the labour of enslaved people. Enslaved West Africans brought deep knowledge of growing indigo. In Mesoamerica meanwhile, probably since around 800, Maya blue was made from indigo and clay.

From European trade and from indigenous knowledge passed down through generations. The oldest documented fabric dyed with indigo comes from Huaca Prieta in Peru and is about six thousand years old.

Indigo is a colour that carries **both**. The beauty of indigenous traditions and the pain of forced labour. **Both are true**.

Indigo in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at indigo **a little differently** and some do not actually describe it directly. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. **Indigo is not among the classical colours of the five elements.** It is closest to water, which is linked with black or dark blue. **Water is the element** of winter, cold, the kidneys and bladder and the emotion of fear. Wisdom and the ability to flow are also grouped with it.

Water is in the tradition the element of **depth and reserves**. It is under the surface and waits. When there is enough of it, we are calm, patient and have something to draw from. When there is little, the tradition describes exhaustion and anxiety. When there is too much, it tends to be a cold closing-off and fear.

How it relates to the colour indigo. Indigo is a deep dark blue and can be read as the colour of water. Of depth, winter and rest, but also of reserves and wisdom. **It is not a classical assignment, it is a reading in the spirit of the tradition.** Indigo has no organ circuit of its own.

What you can take from it. Ask whether you have enough water in your life, that is rest and reserves. If not, sleep, warmth, slow eating and quiet help. When there is too much water and you are rather withdrawn and fearful, movement, warmth and small steps outward help.

Ask yourself

"Do I have enough rest in my life? Where am I afraid, although I would rather flow?"

Reserves. Not everything has to go out at once

In the traditional view water relates to storing, winter and the kidney circuit. The kidneys are also credited with storing the essence jing. For our theme the image of reserves is interesting. **Not everything you have has to be spent outward immediately.** Perhaps you know how to push, overcome tiredness and carry on. It is just that you less often recognise the moment when it would be good to stop before exhaustion stops you.

When you no longer need a dark hush

If you spend whole days in the dim and feel disconnected from your surroundings, another dark corner may not suit you. Try keeping indigo in a smaller detail and adding a lighter surrounding, daylight or a warmer material. **You do not have to stay in winter** just because it has a beautiful colour.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor. A colour itself does not strengthen the kidneys and does not replace recovery of strength.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. In it a person is described by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. Indigo is cooling, deep and calming.

How it relates to the colour indigo. Indigo is among the cold dark colours. That is why, according to some sources, it suits where there is too much fire and irritation. **Indigo does not appear in the lists of classical texts as a separate colour, it is a modern consideration.** Sources differ in detail, take it as a general direction, not a rule.

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. **Indigo cools and calms her.** The tradition advises cooling colours, such as blue, green or white. Indigo can be a dark variant.

- **Add indigo**
  A muted indigo blanket or cushion, a darker blue in a bedroom.
- **Add some cool**
  White and green, water, a walk by a river.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, who is often cold. Cool colours may be too cool for vata. A soft, muted indigo can help calm, especially in combination with warm light. **It is best to notice how you really feel in indigo.**

- **Warmer shades**
  Grey indigo, plum. Calm without coldness.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Gentle shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. Dark and cool colours can deepen heaviness even more. The tradition advises **lively warm colours**.

- **Indigo in moderation**
  Only as an accent, not the whole room.
- **Add warmth**
  Orange, yellow or red as a counterweight. A jumper, scarf, tablecloth.

Contemporary colour therapy. Ranga chikitsa

Some contemporary Ayurvedic practitioners use a colour therapy called ranga chikitsa. They ascribe to indigo insight, imagination and quieting, and in excess they also describe restlessness or too deep an immersion in the inner world. For your own experience you can try a simple comparison. Do I prefer a deep indigo by itself, or with a light and warmer companion?

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe indigo as a separate colour. He did, however, link blue with thinking (“thinking is white or blue, cold as snow”) and with the mental process, reason (Greek nous). In 1933 he wrote that the unconscious “usually chooses” blue instead of black. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thought, not Jung's statement.

How it relates to the colour indigo. Indigo is a darker, deeper blue. It could be the colour of a moment when **thinking sinks into the unconscious**. **A quiet space in which things arrange themselves** into connections before we put them into words.

What you can take from it. When you are overwhelmed by the daily rush, indigo in the form of evening helps. A moment when you ask what you actually felt all day. When, on the contrary, you live only in your own head and perceive nothing through the senses, green (body and senses) or red (feeling) may do you good.

Jung did not want colours to be made into a dictionary. **He himself said** that correspondences change according to the person and culture and appear only “with a certain regularity”. **We always ask what it means for you.** Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In it indigo is not a separate colour. It is closest to dark blue and black, which belong to **water**, the element of calm, depth and flow. Water belongs to winter and to the direction north. In the map of the house called the bagua, north is linked with career and life path. Indigo is therefore usually the colour of **calm and depth**, not of brightening.

According to the tradition water feeds wood (which is why green belongs with indigo), metal feeds water. Fire and water, on the other hand, “fight”. That is why for a dark blue a balance with a warm colour is recommended, so that the space is not too cold.

Simple tips

- **Want more calm?**
  Start with one indigo piece, for example a cushion or lamp, in a place where you will see it every day.
- **For every day**
  Choose grey indigo or denim. Keep a deep midnight for small accents.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, wool and light and warm colours.
- **Indigo does not suit you?**
  Swap it for another colour. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH **Dark walls make a room cosy** always.

TRUTH It depends on the light. In a small room without windows a dark colour can feel cramped. In a spacious room with good lighting it can be cosy.

MYTH Indigo is suitable for a bedroom because it sends you to sleep.

TRUTH For some calming helps, for others a dark room does not improve sleep. What decides is how it feels to fall asleep in it.

MYTH The more indigo, the more intuition.

TRUTH **A colour does not raise intuition.** It can only create a calm environment in which it is easier to perceive.

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Clothing

Indigo in clothing is calm and trustworthy. It suits when you want to seem composed. When dark colours pull you down, **add a light or warm colour near the face**. Let your body and the mirror advise you.

What indigo works well with

- **Cream and warm white**
  A lighter, softer whole.
- **Wood and linen**
  A more natural and warmer impression.
- **Ochre or yellow**
  A striking light spot.
- **Terracotta and orange**
  A warm companion for a deep blue.
- **Soft pink**
  A softer, more personal expression.
- **Green and black**
  Green recalls a landscape at dusk. Black is a very deep pairing in which differences disappear.

Before you repaint a whole room, try **a throw**, **a fabric** or a larger colour **sample**. Hold a large sample to the wall and look at it in the morning and in the evening in your own lighting. A screen does not replace the shade.

When a whole “fights energetically”, do not look for an invisible flaw. **Try changing one concrete thing**. The proportion of colours, a material, the light or the size of an area. Feng shui has several schools and the recommendations differ. Take them as inspiration for how it feels to live in a space.

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Feng shui room by room

What works, what to watch for and a simple tip.

Living room

What works. An indigo cushion, picture or one wall. **It suits mainly the north part** of a room. **An indigo sofa or armchair** can give a light room a striking centre. Let the rest be light.

What to watch for. If you already have a dark floor, furniture and little daylight, start with a smaller accessory. Another large dark area can strengthen the closed-in feeling that already bothers you.

A simple tip. Linen, wool and wood warm indigo and make it friendlier. Glossy satin and glass cool it and emphasise its hardness.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Indigo can be beautiful on ceramics, lower cabinets or place mats. In a light space it creates a striking **contrast that lets the food stand out**.

What to watch for. In a small dark kitchen a smaller amount may be more pleasant. Blue lighting over food as the main light I would not choose. It changes the look of the food.

A simple tip. Matt ceramics or wood with indigo feel friendlier than glossy lacquer. Natural materials ground it and bring it closer to the food.

Bedroom

What works. A soft, muted indigo can help with calming. Indigo bed linen can be pleasant if you like deep colours and a feeling of being enveloped. **Start with a textile.** You will find out how you feel next to it in the morning and in the evening, and it is easy to change.

What to watch for. Whole walls in a dark colour can feel heavy, so balance them with warm textiles. If a room feels cold, try cream, linen or wood.

A simple tip. Cotton and linen in indigo are pleasant to look at and to touch. Gloss does not make falling asleep much easier. What do you see just before you fall asleep and how does it feel to look at it?

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Children's room

What works. A night sky by agreement. Only as an accent, not the whole room. An indigo throw or cushion is soft and easy to replace.

What to watch for. Children need more light. One child will love an indigo corner, another will not want to fall asleep in it. When a child is afraid of a dark place, their experience takes precedence over the rule that blue calms.

Study

What works. Indigo helps concentration in a small dose. It can stand out on a bookcase, a picture or a smaller wall. If it pleases you, it supports the personal character of a workplace.

What to watch for. A too dark room tires. For reading and detailed work you need suitable lighting. When dark surroundings dull you, keep the main work view lighter.

A simple tip. Matt wood or paper leave indigo in the background. A glossy dark surface in the field of view can reflect into the eyes.

Hall and entrance

What works. Put an indigo accent where good light will surround it. A coat hook, a shelf, a small picture.

What to watch for. Dark colours reduce light, so it needs good lighting.

A simple tip. A matt coating or textile can take knocks and does not reflect light as harshly as gloss. **Does the entrance welcome you**, or does the first look shout at you?

If I asked you now

"Why do I want indigo at home? What is it meant to bring me, calm, depth or focus?"

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Colour frequency and phototherapy

An indigo fabric reflects part of the light, an indigo lamp **emits** light. **The colour of night, the biological clock and light treatment are not one thing**. That is why we cannot transfer the same claims about effects to them.

And it is exactly here that it is good to put **miraculous promises** aside. An indigo lamp is not a magic device for intuition, sleep or chakras.

What frequency means

In the light spectrum the name indigo is used for the region between blue and violet. The exact boundaries of colour names differ. **A darker colour does not automatically mean a higher frequency** or greater spiritual power.

The colour of night does not have to be a light for falling asleep

This is an important contrast with indigo. Indigo bed linen may please you. A strongly blue-glowing lamp, however, with unsuitable evening use can **influence the biological clock**. It depends on the spectrum, intensity, timing and length of exposure to light. **In the evening therefore prefer a weaker, pleasant lighting**. During the day, enough daylight makes sense in turn.

What is happening to the eyes

The eyes need suitable brightness and contrast according to the activity. If you decipher fine print in indigo dimness, the colour **will not replace** the missing working light. During longer close work now and then look into the distance and let the eyes rest.

Phototherapy has a specific purpose

For seasonal winter depression bright light treatment is used according to a set procedure. Its principle does not lie in an indigo shade or in a link with the third eye. **For an ordinary indigo lamp the ability** to treat depression, adjust hormones or open a chakra is not reliably proven. Discuss the suitability of light treatment with a doctor or the relevant health professional. For your own ritual you can **stay with a fabric, a picture or a gentle visualisation**.

Questions for you

In what light is it easy for me to slow down in the evening?

Am I making a medicine of the lamp, or enjoying it as atmosphere?

Am I getting enough daylight?

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Astrotype and colours

Are you Pisces, Sagittarius, Capricorn, or another sign? Astrological type is a much broader topic than just the sun sign. If you want to go really into **depth**, knowing only the date of birth is not enough. The exact place and time of birth matter too, because only from them are the ascendant, the position of the Moon, the planets and other parts of the horoscope calculated. Here, though, we really keep only to the edge of what relates to colours.

You will not find indigo in classical sources on the planets. The closest are dark blue and violet shades. For Jupiter, according to one source (digitalambler), blue, green, violet and white are given, for Saturn black. Indigo lies between blue and violet, and that is why I link it with Jupiter (Sagittarius, Pisces) and, as a colour of night and depth, with Saturn (Capricorn, Aquarius) and with the water signs (Cancer, Scorpio, Pisces). It is my own reflection in the spirit of the tradition, not a rule.

The ascendant is the sign that was rising on the eastern horizon at the moment of your birth. According to astrological tradition it shows how you come across outwardly and how you enter the world, while the Sun sign describes more who you are inside. For each sign you will therefore find not only its character but also a short note on how the colour fits when it is your ascendant.

Aries (21 March – 19 April)

Your indigo

classic indigo · denim · blue-violet

An indigo that **calms** you when the pace sets you off running.

Aries is linked in astrology with Mars, fire and the start of spring. It is quick and direct. Indigo is for it a brake with reason. It gives you **perspective** without taking away **courage**.

What Aries is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality cardinal · ruler Mars

Aries opens the zodiac and you can tell that it is first. It is a **pioneer** who gets into things before thinking them through perfectly. It is direct, impatient and likes to compete. It gets angry quickly but forgives quickly too.

Its strength is the **courage** to begin. Weaker is perseverance in long, slow matters. It does best where something is happening and where it can act at once.

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What it can support in you

Indigo can support moments when you want to wait before setting off. It suits places where your energy is quicker than your plan.

With Aries, strength is in decision. A calm indigo can add consideration.

Shadow hesitating in the dark instead of the first step

In the shadow Aries gets stuck in the head. Instead of going, it thinks, and brave speed turns into a quiet simmering inside.

Aries does not like delays. A very dark indigo may seem slow and heavy to you.

And once you burrow into thinking, a deep blue gives you another reason not to go.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **slow down to one thought** and then say it or do it.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mars red as an accent.

red · cream · orange

They add a spark and warmth so that indigo is not only heavy.

Aries as ascendant

When Aries is your ascendant, you come across as direct, lively and decisive. People may see you as someone who gets straight to the point, and the first impression tends to be brisk.

Indigo calms your impression and adds credibility, but does not take away your courage. Denim shades suit you more than midnight.

In everyday life

*Keep indigo for moments when you need to **take a breath** before saying something.*

When you set off too fast, give yourself one dark blue place in the flat. It will remind you that the pace can be slowed even with enthusiasm.

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Taurus (20 April – 20 May)

Your indigo

denim · grey indigo · slate

Indigo as **favourite jeans**. Comfortable and familiar.

Taurus is an earth sign linked with Venus, the senses and stability. Indigo suits it as a fabric, not as an idea. Denim, linen and wool give it a security it can **feel with its hands**.

What Taurus is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality fixed · ruler Venus

Taurus is an earthy, **patient** and sensual sign. It likes good food, pleasant materials, nature and security. It gets going slowly, but once it decides on something, it persists.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to enjoy the present moment. The weaker side tends to be stubbornness and finding it hard to let go of what is familiar.

What it can support in you

Indigo can support calm in the body and a feeling that there is nowhere to hurry. It suits places where you want comfort without ostentation.

With Taurus it is often not only about the colour but about the material. Indigo on wool or matt ceramics feels completely different from glossy satin.

Shadow fear of change posing as calm

In the shadow Taurus settles in so thoroughly that it stops moving. A calm that acts as certainty is sometimes just fear of changing something.

Taurus needs tangibility. A too muted indigo may seem nondescript to you.

And once you are used to it, a dark and deep colour further supports a feeling that it is better to let go of nothing.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you tell **what is real calm** and what is just comfort, and make one small change.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Venus green or pink.

green · pink · light wood

They add liveliness and warmth so that indigo is not only muted.

Taurus as ascendant

When Taurus is your ascendant, you come across as calm, stable and pleasant. You build trust slowly and people often feel firm ground in you.

Denim and grey indigo add naturalness.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind you that comfort and depth do not exclude each other. ***Treat yourself to them.***

Take the ***jeans*** *or jumper you like best and notice how you feel in them. That is your indigo.*

Gemini (21 May – 20 June)

Your indigo

bluer indigo · dusk · plum

Indigo as **a calm canvas** for your thoughts.

Gemini is linked with Mercury, movement and curiosity. Indigo gives them a space where their thoughts can stop for a while and **settle**.

What Gemini is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Gemini is **curious**, talkative and adaptable. It learns quickly, likes to tell stories and enjoys it when a lot is going on around it. It can see several sides of one thing.

Its strength is **lightness** and wit. The weaker side tends to be scatteredness and a tendency to start more things than can be finished.

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What it can support in you

Indigo can give a quick head a moment of calm. It suits places where your thoughts jump around and you want to stop for a while.

Gemini is often happy with lighter shades. **Dusk** or denim shades are more playful than midnight.

Shadow imagining stories nobody has confirmed

In the shadow Gemini writes stories for others and for itself. From one look or sentence a whole conversation arises that never happened.

Gemini gets bored quickly. A very dark indigo may strengthen your inner voice.

And when you keep thinking in circles, another dark and quiet colour gives you no new stimulus.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **check one thing with another person** instead of imagining it.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Mercury blue or orange.

light blue · orange · white

They add playfulness and air so that indigo is not only serious.

Gemini as ascendant

When Gemini is your ascendant, you come across as lively, friendly and chatty. People may see you as curious and youthful, even if inside you are perhaps calmer.

A dusk and denim indigo catch their lightness, midnight would weigh it down.

In everyday life

Indigo can be a calm background for ideas. Evening, a candle and paper.

When your head starts racing, try writing one thought on indigo paper and leaving the rest until morning.

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Cancer (21 June – 22 July)

Your indigo

midnight · classic indigo · smoky blue-violet

Indigo as **night water**. Deep and safe.

Cancer is linked with the Moon, water and the start of summer. It is caring and sensitive. Indigo is for it the colour of night water in which it can safely **grow quiet**.

What Cancer is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality cardinal · ruler Moon

Cancer is **caring**, sensitive and strongly connected to home and family. It has a good memory for feelings and relationships. It enters the world cautiously, much like a crab with its shell.

Its strength is **empathy** and the ability to create safety. The weaker side tends to be changeable moods and a tendency to withdraw when it feels hurt.

What it can support in you

Indigo can support a feeling of home and the wish to wrap yourself up. It suits an evening, a blanket and a cushion that embrace you.

With Cancer it is important that the colour is soft. Smoky and faded tones suit it more than sharp and hard ones.

Shadow replaying old words in the evening

In the shadow Cancer returns in the evening to what someone said and what should have been said differently. The depth of night turns into a carousel that resolves nothing.

Cancer is vulnerable. A very dark indigo can strengthen longing and loneliness.

And when you go round and round in your head, a deep blue keeps you in it.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **write or say one thing aloud** and let the rest go.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Moon white and silver.

moon white · silver · apricot

They add light and warmth so that the night is not only cold.

Cancer as ascendant

When Cancer is your ascendant, you come across as gentle and careful. At first you keep your distance, but then warmth unfolds and people see in you someone who will look after them.

Smoky and grey indigo add calm, a very dark one would act like a curtain.

In everyday life

Indigo in a soft fabric and in evening light is safest for you.

Give yourself something warming for yourself, not just for others. ***Warm yourself too.***

Leo (23 July – 22 August)

Your indigo

midnight · plum · indigo with gold

An indigo that gives your radiance **dignity**.

Leo is linked with the Sun, creativity and joy. Indigo is its counterpart, the night sky on which radiance stands out. With a gold accessory it feels **regal**.

What Leo is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality fixed · ruler Sun

Leo is **generous**, proud and creative. It likes to give, likes to rejoice and needs others to see and appreciate it. It is loyal and has a big heart.

Its strength is **warmth** and the ability to inspire others. The weaker side tends to be sensitivity to criticism and a tendency to want to be the centre of attention.

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What it can support in you

Indigo can support self-expression in a calm form. Midnight and plum carry prestige without shouting.

Leo often does not need permission to be seen. Indigo reminds it that strength can also be quiet.

Shadow withdrawing into shadow so that someone notices

In the shadow Leo falls silent and waits to see whether anyone notices it is missing. Quiet pride turns into a passive test of those around.

Leo does not want to go unnoticed. Indigo alone may seem not radiant enough to you.

And when you are withdrawing, a dark colour strengthens the whole retreat even more.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **say what you want before you have to wait** for someone to notice.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Sun gold and yellow.

gold · sun yellow · cream

They add light so that indigo does not stay only in shadow.

Leo as ascendant

When Leo is your ascendant, you come across as self-assured, warm and striking. You enter a room in a way that people notice you even when you do not want them to.

Midnight and plum with a drop of gold add dignity.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind Leo that being seen does not mean proving your worth.

Night does not need applause to be beautiful. ***The stars shine anyway.***

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Virgo (23 August – 22 September)

Your indigo

denim · slate · classic indigo

An indigo that gives order **calm**.

Virgo is an earth sign linked with Mercury, detail and practicality. Indigo suits it as the colour of ink, notes and **focused work**. It gives clarity without needless decoration.

What Virgo is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Virgo is **meticulous**, attentive and practical. It notices details that others overlook and likes to be useful. It tends to be modest and judges itself more strictly than others.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to improve things. The weaker side tends to be perfectionism, worries and a tendency to criticise itself.

What it can support in you

Indigo can support concentration and a feeling that things have their place. Jeans, a notebook or a dark ribbon on the desk.

With Virgo indigo works in muted, sober shades. Slate and denim add calm without a label of strictness.

Shadow analysis instead of rest

In the shadow Virgo analyses even when it should already be resting. Depth turns into drilling that finds nothing because it keeps looking for more.

Virgo is critical, above all of itself. A dark indigo can strengthen the critical inner voice.

And when you dissect every detail, a deep blue gives you more room for thinking.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **put the notebook aside** and allow yourself one moment without analysis.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Mercury blue or white.

light blue · white · sand

They add purity and air so that indigo is not only strict.

Virgo as ascendant

When Virgo is your ascendant, you come across as neat, restrained and reliable. People see you as observant and sensible, sometimes even overly reserved.

Denim and slate suit it more than a striking midnight.

In everyday life

Indigo can be the colour of an evening notebook. A few sentences about what you really felt today.

Something can be good enough even without a final correction. ***Let the depth be.***

Libra (23 September – 22 October)

Your indigo

grey indigo · dusk · plum

An indigo that brings **quiet elegance** and balance.

Libra is linked with Venus, beauty and balance. Indigo gives it **quiet** elegance and calm. It is a colour that does not have to stress that it is pretty.

What Libra is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality cardinal · ruler Venus

Libra longs for **harmony**, beauty and justice. It is diplomatic, sociable and has a feel for aesthetics. It lives best in relationships in which it does not feel alone.

Its strength is **tact** and the ability to see both sides. The weaker side tends to be hesitation and a tendency to avoid conflict even when it would help.

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What it can support in you

Indigo can support balance between what you give and what you receive. It suits places where you look for calm between two sides.

Libra has a feeling for aesthetics. Grey indigo and dusk shades add balance and elegance.

Shadow seeking confirmation from others instead of your own voice

In the shadow Libra asks everyone around before it allows itself its own opinion. The deep inner voice gets a word only after all the others, sometimes never.

Libra finds it hard to decide. If light is missing, indigo can be too serious.

And when you hesitate, a dark and quiet colour does not help you hear what you actually want.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **write down a first impression before you ask others**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Venus green, pink or white.

pink white green

They add tenderness and light so that indigo is not only serious.

Libra as ascendant

When Libra is your ascendant, you come across as elegant, pleasant and balanced. People like you for your tact, even if inside you take a long time to decide.

Grey indigo and dusk shades are their colours of harmony.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind Libra that your own opinion does not have to be loud to be valid.

Try five minutes of quiet before deciding. ***What does your first hunch tell you?***

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Scorpio (23 October – 21 November)

Your indigo

midnight · plum · indigo with black

An indigo with **depth** and mystery.

Scorpio is a water sign and in traditional astrology is also linked with Mars, intensity and inner strength. Indigo is its colour of deep water, where only someone who is not afraid of the dark can reach.

What Scorpio is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality fixed · ruler Mars, in the newer view also Pluto

Scorpio is **intense**, deep and loyal. It feels strongly, but does not always show it. It dislikes superficiality and likes to get to what is hidden.

Its strength is **determination** and the ability to transform. The weaker side tends to be distrust, jealousy and a need to keep things under control.

What it can support in you

Indigo can support the ability to transform, calm and deep rest. A night by the water is Scorpio's indigo.

Scorpio cannot bear superficiality. Indigo in a dark, natural shade carries dignity and depth.

Shadow burying yourself in your own depth

In the shadow Scorpio sinks deeper and deeper until it loses contact with people. Depth that was meant to be a source becomes a hiding place.

Scorpio cannot bear superficiality. A light and airy indigo may seem shallow to you.

And when you are closing in, dark water lets you stay beneath the surface even longer.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **surface to one person** and tell them what is happening.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Mars dark red.

wine · gold · beige

They add warmth and light so that depth is not only cold.

Scorpio as ascendant

When Scorpio is your ascendant, you come across as focused, mysterious and strong. People sense the intensity of your gaze and often feel that you know more than you say.

Midnight and plum underline its depth.

In everyday life

*Indigo can remind Scorpio that **the deep** is beautiful, but you can breathe only at the surface.*

*Depth is not the same as solitude. **Take someone with you.***

Sagittarius (22 November – 21 December)

Your indigo

bluer indigo · denim · dusk

The indigo of the **night sky**, roads and distances.

Sagittarius belongs to Jupiter, fire and movement. You will not find indigo in old sources on the planets, but it lies between blue and violet, which according to some sources are linked with Jupiter. It is the colour of **the night sky** above a road.

What Sagittarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter

Sagittarius is **optimistic**, open and free-spirited. It loves travel, new experiences and the search for meaning. It speaks honestly, sometimes a little too directly.

Its strength is **enthusiasm** and faith in a good outcome. The weaker side tends to be impatience with detail and a tendency to promise more than can be managed.

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What it can support in you

Indigo can support the wish to set off on a journey and look into the distance. The night sky, stars and a view of the horizon are its language.

Sagittarius loves freedom. Indigo gives it a space in which it can breathe and search.

Shadow darkness after big plans go out

In the shadow Sagittarius loses faith when a plan does not work out. Without a goal on the horizon darkness surrounds it, in which it does not know which way to go.

Sagittarius cannot bear restriction. A very dark indigo may seem restrictive to you.

And when you are disappointed, a deep blue may tell you that the road has ended, even though it has not.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **find one small road** for tomorrow instead of the whole big plan.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Jupiter blue or green.

sky blue · green · cream

They add perspective and liveliness so that indigo is not only a boundary.

Sagittarius as ascendant

When Sagittarius is your ascendant, you come across as open, jovial and adventurous. People see you as someone with a wide outlook and an appetite for discovery.

Denim and a bluer indigo suit its wish to set off.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind Sagittarius that even night has stars that show the direction.

You do not have to manage three continents today. ***One walk at dusk is enough.***

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Capricorn (22 December – 19 January)

Your indigo

midnight · slate · classic indigo

An indigo that gives **seriousness and perseverance**.

Capricorn is an earth sign linked with Saturn, structure and perseverance. Indigo is associated with darkness and winter and suits Capricorn as the colour of calm seriousness, like a dark winter night.

What Capricorn is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality cardinal · ruler Saturn

Capricorn is **responsible**, goal-oriented and disciplined. It likes to build and is not afraid of a long road. It has a dry sense of humour and shows it only to those it trusts.

Its strength is **perseverance** and the ability to see things through. The weaker side tends to be strictness with itself, reserve and a tendency to put joy off until later.

What it can support in you

Indigo can support calm and a feeling that things have their time. Midnight and slate carry a dignity that suits Capricorn.

With Capricorn indigo can remind that rest is not laziness. Winter too is part of the year.

Shadow loneliness in a role that has to hold out

In the shadow Capricorn holds its role so firmly that nobody gets behind it. Seriousness protects, but at the same time separates.

Capricorn is strict with itself. A dark indigo can strengthen this strictness even more.

And when you feel alone, a deep blue offers you calm, not company.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **put the role aside for a while** and be with someone without a task.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Something just for pleasure.

warm white · apricot · soft natural materials

They add softness so that indigo is not only duty.

Capricorn as ascendant

When Capricorn is your ascendant, you come across as serious, mature and reserved. People may see you as older than you are, and only later discover how funny you are.

Slate and classic indigo suit it and add calm.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind you that you do not have to work for joy first.

A soft scarf in indigo and a cup of tea. ***Nothing more is needed.***

Aquarius (20 January – 18 February)

Your indigo

blue-violet · grey indigo · bluer

The indigo of **independence** and the night sky.

Aquarius is linked with independence, originality and the need to go its own way. According to tradition it is also linked with Saturn. Indigo suits it as the colour of the night sky from which it looks at the world with perspective.

What Aquarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality fixed · ruler Saturn, in the newer view also Uranus

Aquarius is **independent**, original and idealistic. It is interested in ideas, humanity and the future. It wants to go its own way and does not like adapting to expectations.

Its strength is **perspective** and the ability to come up with new things. The weaker side tends to be distance from feelings and a tendency to withdraw when there is too much closeness.

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What it can support in you

Indigo can support the courage to be different and stay calm inside. Blue-violet and grey indigo feel modern and independent.

Aquarius often does not need a “right” indigo. It needs one that nobody expected yet.

Shadow watching the world from a distance without taking part

In the shadow Aquarius watches events as a spectator. Perspective turns into aloofness and observing replaces involvement.

Aquarius does not like predictability. If colour is missing, indigo can seem aloof.

And when you are alone, a dark sky gives you another reason just to watch.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **get involved in one concrete thing** with people, not just watch.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

One unexpected colour accent.

gold · magenta · grey

They add surprise so that indigo is not only expected.

Aquarius as ascendant

When Aquarius is your ascendant, you come across as independent, a little unusual and friendly. People see you as an original personality who keeps their own space.

Indigo in an unexpected combination, for example with gold or magenta, underlines originality.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind Aquarius that originality does not have to mean solitude.

Sometimes the boldest colour is the one everyone wears. ***But you wear it your own way.***

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Pisces (19 February – 20 March)

Your indigo

dusk · smoky blue-violet · plum

Indigo as **the deep**, dreams and silence.

Pisces is a water sign linked with imagination, sensitivity and the inner world. According to some sources it is linked with Jupiter. Indigo is the colour of depths, dreaming and silence and suits Pisces naturally.

What Pisces is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter, in the newer view also Neptune

Pisces is **empathic**, intuitive and dreamy. It picks up the moods around it and often has a rich imagination. It frequently has a bond with art, music and spirituality.

Its strength is **compassion** and creative fantasy. The weaker side tends to be merging with other people's feelings, escaping into dreams and difficulty setting boundaries.

What it can support in you

Indigo can support calm, grounding and a feeling that you can let yourself be carried. Dusk and smoky tones are your language.

With Pisces it is important that indigo is not hard. Faded, soft and bleeding areas suit you more than rich and sharp ones.

Shadow dissolving in a depth whose bottom you cannot see

In the shadow Pisces sinks so deep that it loses contact with the surface. Dreams and feelings merge and you no longer know where you end and your surroundings begin.

Pisces easily dissolves. A very dark indigo can disconnect you from your surroundings.

And when you are full of impressions, another depth only adds weight.

The colour can help you here too. It helps you **return to the body** and do one small thing with your hands.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Jupiter blue, green and soft shades of water.

sky blue · green · cream

They add light and depth so that indigo is not only muted.

Pisces as ascendant

When Pisces is your ascendant, you come across as gentle, dreamy and adaptable. People like to project their wishes onto you and tend to be kind to you.

Dusk and smoky shades suit them, midnight would overpower the softness.

In everyday life

Indigo can remind you that gentleness is strength.

When your day dissolves, do one small thing with your hands. ***Make tea or water a flower.***

FOR A DEEPER LOOK

- **Seasons**

Indigo is the colour of winter night, dusk and the deep sea. Capricorn and Aquarius belong to winter, Pisces to its end. Ask yourself when you reach for indigo.

- **Time of day**

Indigo is the colour of dusk and night. In the evening it calms, in the morning it may be too muted.

- **Years of life**

Saturn returns to the place where it was at your birth at roughly 27 to 31 years and again between 56 and 60. Astrology reads this as a time of reassessment and a new order. In these years indigo may feel close to you, or on the contrary foreign. Both are natural. Research by Palmer and Schloss (2010) reports that we like colours according to the things and experiences we associate with them. Astrology does not rule this out, it just offers another view.

A question for you

"When do I like indigo best. Morning, evening, winter, summer?"

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Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you promise depth, expertise or calm. But indigo is not a promise for free.

In business indigo is a colour that **does not shout and is still seen**. It acts like a person who does not have to raise their voice to be listened to. It is deep, expert and a little mysterious, and that is why it is good to know what it promises before you let it into a logo, a website or an advertisement.

By itself, though, it does not attract customers like a magnet. It can help create **a trustworthy impression**, but what mainly decides is still what you sell, to whom and how well it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Indigo can say, for example

"Things are done properly here." "I do not have to shout." "I have time for your opinion." "It is personal."

- **Depth and expertise.** A dark, calm blue seems trustworthy. The customer reads that things are done properly here.
- **Wisdom and prestige.** Quiet luxury brands use it as a colour of quality that does not have to stress itself.
- **Everydayness.** It is the colour of jeans and therefore of work and comfort. It can be prestigious and ordinary at once.
- **Mystery.** It is linked with night, dream and the inner world. It suits where you offer an experience, not a thing.
- **Distance.** It is a cold and dark colour. When you do not balance it with warmth, it can seem aloof.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also act differently. Midnight is **prestigious and calm**, denim **everyday and friendly**, dusk (light) **gentle and dreamy**, grey indigo **sober and elegant**.

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Simple tips

As a base, not as a wall

It suits as the main colour of a logo or text, because it is legible on a light background. For large areas mute it and balance it with light.

Shade by role

Midnight and dark for prestige and calm, denim for everydayness, dusk for tenderness and dreams, grey indigo for sobriety and elegance.

Combinations

Gold or silver for prestige, white for clarity, yellow and orange for warmth, pink for tenderness.

Cultural context

In Japan indigo is a traditional colour of elegance, in India and in America it also carries a story of forced labour, in the New Age it is linked with intuition. Find out what it means for you and for them.

Legibility

For ordinary text a contrast of at least 4.5 to 1 is recommended (the WCAG accessibility rule). A dark background with dark text is illegible, put dark on light and vice versa.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Do not use these two colours as the only difference between two things.

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Professions where it is a Yes

Research, education and consulting

Indigo can accompany a thoughtful and calm presentation. Let it stand out on headings or smaller areas. If you offer personal work, also add your own face and understandable words. **Expertise does not have to look like a room where you are afraid to ask anything.**

Therapy, coaching, meditation and sleep

Indigo can be an understandable symbol of an inner view. A visitor, though, also needs to find out what, when, where and for how much. Intuition can have room, searching for the sign-up form does not have to be her final exam.

Writing, art, photography and music

A deep ground can let a work or photograph stand out. But if an indigo filter covers everything, the colour starts to tell mainly about itself. Keep the real shades of the work.

Textiles, denim, indigo printing and craft

Here indigo connects directly to the material and its history. **The colour does not have to pretend a story. The product already has one.** It can be a natural part of a label, packaging and a website. Give room to details of the fabric and the real way of working.

Professions where it is a No

It is not a ban on the colour. Amount and context decide. Here I would go easy on large areas.

- **Loud and cheerful brands.** Children's play, entertainment, fast food, sales and everywhere you need to catch attention at once. Indigo will be too serious.
- **Services where the customer needs to feel warmth and closeness first.** A dark tone alone can seem more serious than you want.
- **Small dark spaces.** A dominant indigo can strengthen a closed-in impression.
- **Crisis and orientation information.** Clarity takes precedence over a mysterious atmosphere.
- **Presentation of food, skin and colour-sensitive products.** Coloured light or a filter can distort the look.
- **Long texts.** They need well readable contrast and enough space.

The rule is simple. When you sell depth, expertise and calm, indigo will help you. When you sell cheerfulness and quick decisions, it will be too serious.

Before you send it into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the indigo?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that indigo means depth and intuition.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

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Examples from the market

You know indigo from jeans and payment cards. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Levi's (jeans)**
  On 20 May 1873 Levi Strauss and the tailor Jacob Davis obtained a patent for metal rivets in work trousers. Jeans are classically dyed with indigo. Aha. A colour that changes over time is part of the magic. Jeans "adapt" to a person.

- **Visa (payments)**
  The name Visa arose in 1976 and the brand kept the blue-white-gold flag. According to the company, blue and gold were meant to recall the blue sky and golden hills of California. Aha. A colour can also carry the place a brand comes from.

- **G-Star RAW (jeans)**
  The company was founded in Amsterdam by Jos van Tilburg in 1989. In 1996 came jeans from unwashed and untreated denim, so-called raw denim. Aha. Raw fabric changes as you wear it and every pair eventually becomes different.

- **Wrangler (jeans)**
  Jeans for cowboys were introduced by the Blue Bell company in 1947. The model was later called 13MWZ after the weight of the denim, 13 ounces per yard. The name was chosen by employees in a competition. Aha. Blue denim carries work and durability here.

What they share is that indigo carries a simple message. **Reliability, calm, craft**. And durability is the best advertising. A colour that lasts gains trust without words.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, customers and how consistent a brand is. Take it as an idea you will check, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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Different colour combinations

Indigo + red

How it feels

Warmth in depth. Red is warm and strong. With indigo it makes a rich, deep pair (burgundy, plum). Mixed together they give violet. Indigo mutes red and red warms indigo.

When it suits

When you want **depth with passion**, but not shouting.

Specific shades



indigo + red
deeply



midnight + wine
mysteriously



denim + terracotta
softly



plum + scarlet
dramatically



grey indigo + brick
earthily

In practice

An indigo wall and a red cushion. Red lipstick and an indigo coat.

Watch out

Large areas of both can feel **heavy**.

Indigo + orange

How it feels

Warmth in the dark. Orange is the opposite of blue. With indigo it makes a strong contrast, like a setting sun on an evening sky. Orange lights indigo up and indigo calms orange.

When it suits

When you want to **light up** a dark whole.

Specific shades



indigo + orange
radiantly



midnight + pumpkin
richly



denim + apricot
softly



grey indigo + terracotta
earthily



dusk + peach
gently

In practice

An indigo scarf and an orange lamp. An indigo wall with an orange accessory.

Watch out

A rich orange on a large area overpowers the calm of indigo. An **accent** is enough.

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Indigo + yellow

How it feels

Light in the dark. Yellow is the opposite of violet and with indigo makes a strong contrast. Gold on the night sky, stars.

When it suits

When you want **one light spot** in the middle of depth.

Specific shades


indigo + lemon
strikingly


midnight + golden
festively


denim + buttery
springlike


grey indigo + mustard
earthily


dusk + vanilla
gently

In practice

A yellow accessory in an indigo room. A yellow candle and an indigo blanket.

Watch out

When there is too much yellow, it can **disturb**.

Indigo + green

How it feels

A forest after sunset. Green and indigo are cool neighbours. Together they recall a deep forest or sea darkness.

When it suits

When you want **calm and depth**.

Specific shades


indigo + green
quietly


midnight + bottle green
deeply


denim + sage
airily


grey indigo + olive
earthily


dusk + mint
freshly

In practice

Indigo and dark green in a bedroom. A green scarf and indigo jeans.

Watch out

When warmth is missing, the mood tends to be **quiet and cold**.

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Indigo + blue

How it feels

Calm in several shades. Blue is its lighter sister. Side by side they look like two versions of the same colour. Blue softens indigo, indigo deepens blue.

When it suits

When you want **calm, tone on tone**.

Specific shades


indigo + cobalt
calmly


midnight + light blue
starrily


denim + sky blue
airily


grey indigo + smoky blue
gently


dusk + icy blue
freshly

In practice

Blue and indigo textiles. Jeans and a light blue shirt.

Watch out

Tone on tone is calm, but it can feel **monotonous**.

Indigo + violet

How it feels

Mystery and depth. Violet is its neighbour on the wheel. Together they are mysterious, dramatic and dreamy. The feeling of a night in which anything can happen.

When it suits

When you want **dreaminess** and imagination.

Specific shades


indigo + violet
magically


dusk + lavender
gently


denim + orchid
playfully


midnight + plum
deeply


grey indigo + lilac
airily

In practice

Indigo and violet in a bedroom. A violet scarf and an indigo coat.

Watch out

Too much violet and indigo can feel **heavy**.

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Indigo + pink

How it feels

Dusk, a soft pair. Pink is red diluted with white. With indigo it is dusk. Indigo gives depth and pink gives kindness.

When it suits

When you want **tenderness and calm**.

Specific shades


indigo + pink
tenderly


dusk + powder pink
gently


midnight + raspberry
deeply


denim + pastel pink
airily


grey indigo + dusty rose
earthily

In practice

Powder pink and indigo in a bedroom. A pink blanket on an indigo sofa.

Watch out

Sweet pastel combinations can feel **childish** if you do not add something earthy.

Indigo + grey

How it feels

Grey indigo **mutes and firms up**. It makes an elegant, sober pair. It helps when there is too much of everything.

When it suits

When you want **distance and calm**.

Specific shades


indigo + grey
calmly


midnight + silver
elegantly


denim + slate
soberly


dusk + light grey
freshly


grey indigo + stone
earthily

In practice

A grey wall with an indigo accessory. A grey dress and an indigo scarf.

Watch out

Too much grey and indigo can feel **dull**.

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Indigo + brown

How it feels

Support and naturalness. Brown and indigo are a natural pair. Jeans and leather, dark wood and the night sky. Indigo carries depth, brown holds the ground.

When it suits

When you want **grounding**.

Specific shades



indigo + brown
naturally



denim + caramel
earthily



dusk + beige
softly



midnight + chocolate
deeply



grey indigo + sand
freshly

In practice

Wooden furniture and indigo textiles. Jeans and brown boots.

Watch out

Both dark, together they can take away light. Add a **light accessory**.

Indigo + white

How it feels

Freshness and order. White gives indigo space and clarity. Indigo stands out next to it, like a nautical style. Indigo breathes and white gives room.

When it suits

When you want a **clean, clear** impression.

Specific shades



indigo + white
cleanly



midnight + cream
elegantly



denim + snow white
freshly



grey indigo + white
calmly



indigo + lilac white
gently

In practice

A white kitchen with indigo accessories. A white shirt and indigo trousers.

Watch out

A pair with too much contrast can feel **austere**.

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Indigo + black

How it feels

Depth to the point of weight. Black and indigo are very close. Side by side they almost merge. An elegant but heavy pair.

When it suits

When you want **evening elegance**.

Specific shades


indigo + black
mysteriously


midnight + charcoal
deeply


denim + graphite
soberly


plum + black
dramatically


grey indigo + black
unobtrusively

In practice

Black accessories and an indigo wall. A black bag with an indigo coat.

Watch out

When there is too much, **light** is missing. Add white or gold.

Indigo + gold

How it feels

Gold on the night sky. Gold and deep blue together recall stars above dusk. Gold lights indigo up, indigo gives gold calm.

When it suits

When you want **prestige with calm**.

Specific shades


indigo + gold
festively


midnight + antique gold
richly


denim + champagne
gently


grey indigo + matte gold
subtly


dusk + pale gold
airily

In practice

A gold piece of jewellery on an indigo coat. Dark blue packaging with gold lettering.

Watch out

Too much gold can feel **showy**. A small accent is enough.

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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **soften** indigo, add **white**, **cream**, **dusk** or **grey**.
- When you want to **ground** it, add **brown**, **wood** or **natural materials**.
- When you want to **light it up**, add **yellow**, **orange** or **gold**.
- When you want to **deepen** it, **midnight**, **plum** or **black** will help.

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